

PROMISING RETURN PRACTICES

POST-RETURN IRAQ

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Name of practice	Reintegration programs	
Dates	2023 - present	
Target group	Returnees	
Geographic Scope	Country	Iraq
	Regions	Asia
	Sub Region	Middle East
Actor	Migration and Displacement Ministry	
Return Stages	Post-Return	
Challenge addressed	Reintegration Sustainability Governance, Cooperation, and Coordination	
Principles referred (implicit or explicit)	Migrants' Agency Human-rights-based approach	

SUMMARY

The National Referral Mechanism is a comprehensive initiative designed to assist returning individuals upon their arrival in Iraq. It facilitates access to their rights and the benefits provided by the Iraqi government, which include healthcare, education, legal support, vocational training services, psychological assistance, employment opportunities, and all necessary elements for successful reintegration. The Mechanism is fully supported and operated by the government and is supervised by the Ministry of Migration and Displacement, with the collaboration of various other ministries, such as Planning, Labour and Social Affairs, Health, Education, Interior, and Higher Education, as well as Iraqi security institutions. Although it is a relatively new mechanism, it plays a crucial role for returnees and offers key features such as connecting them with relevant ministries and non-governmental organizations and providing free services to all returnees from abroad.

These services include individual counselling, referrals to service providers, follow-up assistance during the reintegration process, help in establishing small businesses, employment, vocational and educational training, housing support, legal assistance, protection, medical and mental health support, and help with enrolling children in school. Overall, the Mechanism aims to preserve the dignity and rights of returnees.

BENEFITS/IMPACTS AND SHORTCOMINGS

Since 2023, the National Referral Mechanism has achieved several benefits. It has strengthened coordination across government ministries, institutions, and international and local organisations, replacing previously fragmented responses with a more coherent support framework for returnees.

The NRM has facilitated access to health, education, and social services through targeted referrals: of the 2,000 individuals registered, 1,300 received direct support, including document restoration and correction of identification papers; 700 obtained cash assistance; 20 were referred for residency cards and 40 for national identity cards; 20 accessed healthcare; 20 received school-related documentation and re-entry support; and 500 were referred for training and, in some cases, small business loans.

Through this structure, the NRM has contributed to safeguarding fundamental rights for all individuals irrespective of status, reinforcing alignment with international human rights standards. It has also introduced a monitoring and evaluation system that tracks each case and reassesses progress every six months, improving oversight and service effectiveness. Finally, the NRM has created a central database of returnees, enhancing the availability of accurate, up-to-date information on their profiles and needs.

The NRM has also revealed several structural shortcomings. Coordination and communication gaps persist, with returnees frequently arriving at Baghdad International Airport without advance notice to Iraqi authorities, creating confusion and hindering the reception committee's work. Limited government funding constrains the NRM's ability to deliver services effectively, while the insufficient involvement of civil society organisations weakens complementary psychosocial, social, and training support. The mechanism's focus on Baghdad alone, coupled with a shortage of reception and support centres in the governorates, complicates transport and follow-up for returnees across the country, including those returning to the Kurdistan Region of Iraq.

Awareness of the NRM remains low, reducing uptake of available services among returnees. Broader weaknesses in Iraq's public infrastructure, particularly in health, education, housing, and employment, further restrict the NRM's capacity to provide a suitable environment for returnees. Excessive bureaucracy and administrative routines contribute to frustration and diminish confidence in the mechanism, while limited information-sharing and low mutual trust between host countries and Iraq, especially concerning security, identity, and health data, continue to impede effective coordination.

The NRM has significantly improved the protection of returnees' human and legal rights by establishing a formal framework. However, gaps in coordination and communication can weaken these protections. While it has aided economic and social stabilization for many returnees, funding constraints limit the scale and consistency of these efforts.

The NRM has strengthened cooperation between Iraq and international organisations like the IOM and UNHCR, enhancing returnees' trust in state institutions. Nonetheless, low awareness of the mechanism and uneven service delivery threaten this confidence. It has also improved data collection on returnees, although incomplete coordination with governorates and the Kurdistan Region may hinder data flow. Overall, the NRM showcases Iraq's commitment to international obligations, positively affecting the country's global standing.

KEY LESSONS

Effective return systems depend on strong communication and prior coordination between host and receiving states. When advance information-sharing is weak or inconsistent, reception procedures are disrupted, service delivery is delayed, and authorities face avoidable operational difficulties.

Decentralised reception capacity is essential for effective service delivery and follow-up. While centralisation supports quality control and data management, any country implementing return programmes should ensure the presence of local reception and support centres to facilitate timely assistance and continuous monitoring. In the case of Iraq, while centralisation supports quality assurance and data control, establishing reception and support centres in the governorates and the Kurdistan Region has been essential for timely assistance and effective monitoring.

Transparent information and proactive outreach are critical to ensure returnees have access to available services. Awareness gaps significantly reduce programme uptake; therefore, media outreach must be systematically integrated into all assistance and referral mechanisms.

Reintegration mechanisms cannot succeed without an enabling economic and social environment and meaningful civil society engagement. Even robust referral systems may be undermined by systemic unemployment, poverty, weak public services, or limited NGO involvement in their provision. Continuous monitoring and evaluation are therefore essential to identify gaps, adjust interventions, and make sure that returnees, particularly the most vulnerable, receive the necessary assistance.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Strengthen international coordination and information exchange. Effective return mechanisms require clear, transparent protocols with host countries and robust information-sharing systems to ensure smooth, rights-respecting returns. In Iraq, this includes formal agreements with host states, secure data management, and enhanced cooperation on security, identity, and health information.

Expand and decentralise reception and support infrastructure. Returnees benefit from accessible reception, psychosocial, and reintegration services beyond central locations. In Iraq, establishing centres in major governorates and the Kurdistan Region of Iraq will facilitate timely assistance, continuous monitoring, and better integration outcomes.

Secure sufficient resources and enable civil society participation. Adequate funding, staff capacity, and engagement of NGOs are critical to provide comprehensive services, including psychosocial support, legal assistance, and awareness-raising for returnees. For Iraq, this entails increasing government budget allocations, seeking international support, and integrating civil society in complementary service delivery.

Promote awareness, simplify procedures, and strengthen monitoring. Transparent communication, streamlined administrative procedures, and continuous monitoring improve trust, reduce inefficiencies, and support effective reintegration. In Iraq, this includes raising awareness of the NRM, reducing bureaucratic barriers in document issuance, and establishing independent monitoring and evaluation mechanisms

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